



While some audio purists continue to put wired cans on a pedestal, it is hard to deny how far their wireless counterparts have come from the days when Bluetooth was in its infancy. Today, wireless headphones have come pretty close to eliminating the latency problem that plagued them a few years ago. Wireless headphones are exploding in popularity with some of the bigger names in consumer audio devices putting more time and effort into developing them. This year, we tested a number of good contenders for this burgeoning category. Let's see who came out on the top.

WINNER: SONY WH-1000XM4

Equipped with the custom Sony QN1 processor, the Sony WH-1000XM4 is excellent at combating low to midrange sound frequencies when it comes to external sounds. This is particularly good for isolating sounds from engines when you're in an airplane or car. Additionally, the Mark 4s have gotten even better at cancelling out human voices, although they do struggle to cancel out higher-pitched voices. The sound quality is absolutely pristine as well with well-defined lows



Shure AONIC 50
Price: ₹33,999



AKG K371BT
Price: ₹10,499

and controlled bass response, clear mids, warm vocals, and crisp highs. The bass bias Sony usually has in their headphones is not found here, with a sound signature leaning more towards neutral. The battery life is also excellent, coming in at a respectable 25 hours in our tests. Additionally, the accompanying app offers tons of features and allows users to tweak the EQ settings to their individual preferences as well. Overall, Sony has knocked it out of the park yet again with the Mark 4 headphones and deserves the win in this category.

RUNNER UP: SHURE AONIC 50

The Shure AONIC 50 are one of the closest contenders to the Sony WH-1000XM4's pristine noise-cancelling performance. The ANC on the Shure AONIC 50 is almost as good as the Sony's, which is an impressive feat in itself. You get solid low-end noise cancellation, and a wide array of codecs including SBC, AAC, LDAC, aptX, aptX HD and aptX Low Latency, in comparison to the Sonys that only support the first three. The Shure AONIC 50 sports a sound profile that is slightly closer to neutral than the Sony WH-1000XM4. While this sound profile is excellent for critical listening, it may come off as a bit too restrained and controlled if you're a casual music listener. The accompanying app does have an EQ that allows you to tweak the sonic signature of the headphones, however, you cannot carry over these EQ settings to music playback outside of Shure's app, which is disappointing. These cans sport a decent battery life of approximately 18 hours – on the lower side for wireless headphones in 2020.

BEST BUY: AKG K371BT

Priced at ₹10,499, but often available on discount under 10K, the AKG K371BT are a fabulous value for money purchase owing to the detailed sound reproduction and excellent battery life. These studio headphones offer a solid, close-to-neutral sound profile with great treble clarity. Voices in songs, podcasts, and movies sound ridiculously crisp and detailed without becoming sibilant. Sadly, they only support the SBC and AAC codecs and we wish the company had included support for the aptX codec. Do note that there's no way to adjust the EQ, but the AKG K371BT are a solid pair of headphones for the competitive price tag they sport and give headphones costing almost double the price a run for their money. **4**

– Dhriti Datta

Wireless Headphone

Cordless cans for music lovers



Sony WH-1000XM4
Price: ₹29,990